

BookRead: Software that Reads Books Aloud for You

This software is a boon to the visually challenged as well as readers who want to avoid the strain of spending long hours reading text. It can provide the much-needed rest for tired eyes, and the visually challenged need not have to depend on a caretaker to have books read to them.



The revolution began with the Internet, and there was no stopping the pace of change in the online world. Then came e-books, which revolutionised reading habits. There is, however, a clear difference between dead-tree paper and on-screen text. One can comfortably read for hours on normal paper while this is not advised nor safely possible on laptops and desktop screens.

Since I have to read a lot of books and research papers in my field, the online availability of books is a boon, but I find reading on screen a bottleneck. I can only read for so long before my eyes need a rest. This is the issue that BookRead (also called BKRD) tries to solve. It reads books aloud for you.

BKRD depends on the Espeak module for now, but plans to include other more natural speakers in the future. It is as simple to use as it is elegant. In order to read any book, one simply has to get a plain text copy of it. Conversion to .txt files is a simple enough copy-paste job on most operating systems. After that, BookRead takes care of it all.

Let us try and read a sample book which I have in a file called *sample.pdf*. First, we need to convert this to a .txt file.

1. Open *sample.pdf* with Acrobat (or any other) PDF reader
2. Copy all the text (*Ctrl+A*, then *Ctrl+C*)
3. Open Notepad/Gedit
4. Paste the text with *Ctrl+V*
5. Save the Notepad/Gedit file (we will assume it is saved as

mysample.txt)

Now that we have a text file to read, we need to install BookRead. Let's use an Ubuntu 14 laptop for this demonstration. Open your terminal window (*Ctrl+T*, or search for *Terminal* after pressing the *Windows* key) and enter the following commands. You might be asked for your user password when executing the commands starting with *sudo*.

```
- $ cd ~
- $ sudo apt-get install git
- $ git clone https://github.com/theSage21/BookRead
- $ cd BookRead
- $ sudo chmod u+x bkrd
- $ sudo ln -s bkrd /usr/bin
- $ sudo apt-get install espeak
```

The first command makes sure we are in the home directory of the current user. The second gets *Git* from the Internet. *Git* is the software used to do version control for the BookRead software. The third command gets the BookRead software from the Internet and stores it in a folder called *BookRead*. We then navigate to the newly created folder and make the *BKRD* file executable. Then we make a link to it in the user's binary folder. As a last step, we install Espeak on the machine to allow BookRead to synthesise sound.